off the area where the terrorists were holed up. Apparently, one of the company columns got ambushed on the way. They lost a few soldiers and some others were wounded. The company fought through the ambush, and halted a little distance away. This happened at about 8 p.m. This company never reached the objective at all. During the night, the CO moved up and helped in controlling the situation. Along with the casualties, he pulled back this company to Khanabal, without taking a clearance from the Brigade HQ or even informing us. We were misinformed that the two companies had linked up near the objective area. As a result, throughout the night, we kept conveying incorrect reports to the higher HQ. The next day, when we reached Kokernag, most of the terrorists had slipped through the cordon. One or two of them who were still there threw a few grenades and a splinter hit the corps commander near the eye. Fortunately, it was not very serious, but nonetheless it was a close miss. In the melee, the remaining terrorists also made good their escape. It was a botched-up operation which embarrassed all of us.

As the brigade commander, I accepted full responsibility for the failure of the operation and apologized to the corps and division commanders, namely Lieutenant General Zaki and Major General V.P. Malik (he later became the chief of army staff), respectively. I assured them that we would take corrective measures and ensure that such mistakes did not recur.

At the same time, I took a very serious view of the lapses that had occurred. Tactical mistakes could be understood and corrected, but I could not accept the deliberate act of lying or misinformation by the CO. I requested both the corps and division commanders to consider replacing either me or the CO, as there had been a grave breach of faith between the two of us. Resultantly, I could no longer trust the CO. Having explained the whole scenario to them, I demanded a decision on the spot. Generals Zaki and Malik went into a huddle and after a while took me aside and said that the CO would be relieved from command. I thanked them for the decision and then sought their approval to my proposal that the battalion be disengaged from active operations and trained under my supervision